

CONSTELLATIONS

Patterns in the sky

The sky is divided into 88 areas, most of which contain a recognizable pattern of stars. These constellations help astronomers name stars, describe the positions of planets and comets, and generally find their way around. The naming of celestial regions started around 4,000 years ago.

Around 150 CE, Ptolemy listed the 48 constellations that could be seen from the Mediterranean region. In the 1590s Dutch explorers increased this list when they travelled across the equator to the southern oceans. More additions were made by astronomers in the 17th Century.

THE CONSTELLATIONS (RANKED BY AREA)

Rank	Name	Abbreviation	Named by	Rank	Name	Abbreviation	Named by
1	Hydra	Hya	Ptolemy	45	Grus	Gru	Keyser/De Houtman
2	Virgo	Vir	Ptolemy	46	Lupus	Lup	Ptolemy
3	Ursa Major	UMa	Ptolemy	47	Sextans	Sex	Johannes Hevelius
4	Cetus	Cet	Ptolemy	48	Tucana	Tuc	Keyser/De Houtman
5	Hercules	Her	Ptolemy	49	Indus	Ind	Keyser/De Houtman
6	Eridanus	Eri	Ptolemy	50	Octans	Oct	Nicholas de Lacaille
7	Pegasus	Peg	Ptolemy	51	Lepus	Lep	Ptolemy
8	Draco	Dra	Ptolemy	52	Lyra	Lyr	Ptolemy
9	Centaurus	Cen	Ptolemy	53	Crater	Crt	Ptolemy
10	Aquarius	Aqr	Ptolemy	54	Columba	Col	Pertus Plancius
11	Ophiuchus	Oph	Ptolemy	55	Vulpecula	Vul	Johannes Hevelius
12	Leo	Leo	Babylonian origin	56	Ursa Minor	UMi	Ptolemy
13	Boötes	Boo	Ptolemy	57	Telescopium	Tel	Nicholas de Lacaille
14	Pisces	Psc	Ptolemy	58	Horologium	Hor	Nicholas de Lacaille
15	Sagittarius	Sgr	Ptolemy	59	Pictor	Pic	Nicholas de Lacaille
16	Cygnus	Cyg	Ptolemy	60	Piscis Austrinus	PsA	Ptolemy
17	Taurus	Tau	Babylonian origin	61	Hydrus	Hyi	Keyser/De Houtman
18	Camelopardalis	Cam	Peter Plancius	62	Antlia	Ant	Nicholas de Lacaille
19	Andromeda	And	Ptolemy	63	Ara	Ara	Ptolemy
20	Puppis	Pup	Nicholas de Lacaille	64	Leo Minor	LMi	Johannes Hevelius
21	Auriga	Aur	Ptolemy	65	Pyxis	Pyx	Nicholas de Lacaille
22	Aquila	Aqi	Ptolemy	66	Microscopium	Mic	Nicholas de Lacaille
23	Serpens	Ser	Ptolemy	67	Apus	Aps	Keyser/De Houtman
24	Perseus	Per	Ptolemy	68	Lacerta	Lac	Johannes Hevelius
25	Cassiopeia	Cas	Ptolemy	69	Delphinus	Del	Ptolemy
26	Orion	Ori	Ptolemy	70	Corvus	Crv	Ptolemy
27	Cepheus	Cep	Ptolemy	71	Canis Minor	CMi	Ptolemy
28	Lynx	Lyn	Johannes Hevelius	72	Dorado	Dor	Keyser/De Houtman
28	Libra	Lib	Ptolemy	73	Corona Borealis	CrB	Ptolemy
30	Gemini	Gem	Ptolemy	74	Norma	Nor	Nicholas de Lacaille
31	Cancer	Cnc	Ptolemy	75	Mensa	Men	Nicholas de Lacaille
32	Vela	Vel	Nicholas de Lacaille	76	Volans	Vol	Keyser/De Houtman
33	Scorpius	Sco	Babylonian origin	77	Musca	Mus	Keyser/De Houtman
34	Carina	Car	Nicholas de Lacaille	78	Triangulum	Tri	Ptolemy
35	Monoceros	Mon	Petrus Plancius	79	Chamaeleon	Cha	Keyser/De Houtman
36	Sculptor	Scl	Nicholas de Lacaille	80	Corona Australis	Cra	Ptolemy
37	Phoenix	Phe	Keyser/De Houtman	81	Caelum	Cae	Nicholas de Lacaille
38	Canes Venatici	CVn	Johannes Hevelius	82	Reticulum	Ret	Nicholas de Lacaille
39	Aries	Ari	Ptolemy	83	Triangulum Australe	TrA	Keyser/De Houtman
40	Capricornus	Cap	Babylonian origin	84	Scutum	Sct	Johannes Hevelius
41	Fornax	For	Nicholas de Lacaille	85	Circinus	Cir	Nicholas de Lacaille
42	Coma Berenices	Com	Gerardus Mercator	86	Sagitta	Sge	Ptolemy
43	Canis Major	CMA	Ptolemy	87	Equuleus	Equ	Ptolemy
44	Pavo	Pav	Keyser/De Houtman	88	Crux	Cru	João Faras